



From left: Raveendran Sankaran, Director General & CEO, Bihar State Sports Authority, and B. Rajender, Additional Chief Secretary, Department of Sports, Government of Bihar, in conversation with Ayon Sengupta, Editor, Sportstar, during the Conclave. R.V. MOORTHY

"We are going to cater to 23 sports disciplines - both indoor and outdoor games. After the Asian Champions Trophy, we started coaching camps in hockey for our athletes. Before this, hockey players in Eklavya residential schools didn't have a turf, but now they do. We shifted all our 100 hockey players to Rajgir Sports Academy, and they are getting trained for the first time on a turf. Shortly, they will be mentored by an Olympian. Hockey India has come forward in helping us develop hockey in Bihar. We have started camps for wrestling, weightlifting, athletics, taekwondo, fencing and swimming. Now, slowly, we have started conducting camps in Rajgir Sports Academy. In the future, we will establish a sports science facility there. We will develop it into a high-performance centre for various sports disciplines. Asian Fencing Federation has approached us to come up with an Asian Fencing Academy here. If that happens, the best of Asia's fencers will be coming to Bihar and that will help develop my fencers."

However, Raveendran cautioned against investing in big infrastructure and said that the Bihar government was more in favour of constructing temporary

structures.

"We are not in favour of erecting white elephants. We are planning to create only the field of play as per the requirement of the game. In every panchayat and bloc, we will develop the field of play according to the sport. My boys and girls get more space to play," he added.

Raveendran also said that the State government was actively addressing issues such as age fraud, doping and sexual harassment in sport.

"Three cases came to our knowledge and the girls gave it [complaint] in writing. We lodged cases against the three coaches and sent them behind bars."

Though Bihar hasn't yet medalled for India at the Olympic Games, Raveendran said that the wait would end by 2032 or 2036.

"Our mission was to send at least one athlete from Bihar to the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. But, in 2024 itself, we had athletes from Bihar — Shreyasi Singh (shooting) and Paralympian Shailesh Kumar. We have achieved the 2028 target in 2024 itself. In 2028, we will want to increase our count. In 2032 or 2036, Bihar's children will get a medal for India."